CHAPTER SEVEN

South Africa, Apartheid, and the Road to BDS

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In an article published in 2013 in *Yediot Achronot*, Einat Wilf identified the importance of South Africa as the lynchpin in the global Boycott, Divestment and Sanctions (BDS) assault on Israel. She described it as the "ground zero of initiatives aimed at boycotting and isolating Israel." South Africa, as she termed it, was the "world's conscience" for the Western liberal left. This had become evident at the infamous 2001 World Conference against Racism held in Durban that degenerated into a orgy of anti-Zionism and antisemitism.[1]

For those monitoring developments in South Africa, it had been obvious that the anti-Zionist temperature in South Africa had been rising for decades before the Durban meeting. A new Muslim militancy was already evident in the wake of the United Nations resolution of 1975 that equated Zionism with racism, hailed in *Muslim News*, a national weekly, as a victory for the Palestine Liberation Organisation and a defeat for the United States and Israel.[2] By the late 1970s, a Palestine Islamic Solidarity Committee had been established in Durban and a few years later liberal English-speaking campuses protested vigorously against the Israel-Lebanese war.[3] A decade later Muslims began to take part in mass demonstrations, with the result that—in the words of the BBC—"the streets of Cape Town resembled those of Tehran."[4] Once President F. W. de Klerk lifted the ban on illegal organizations in February 1990 and began the process of dismantling apartheid, marches became even more frequent.[5] It was now common to hear the refrain "One Zionist, one bullet" (a play on a well-known Pan Africanist Congress slogan "one settler, one bullet") during anti-Israel marches. "Jews were invariably equated with blood sucking Zionists," writes the South African Muslim scholar Farid Esack.[6] It was thus no surprise that the *Protocols of the Elders of Zion* was on sale at the Durban Conference against racism.

Although a Pew Poll based on the urban population study conducted in 2007 indicated that 28 percent of South Africans sided with Israel in the Israeli-Palestinian conflict as opposed to 19 percent with the Palestinians, and although the ANC-led government currently accepts the two-state solution,

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